

MISSION
NEPTUNE

EXPLORING PLANET OCEAN

NEPTUNE | FORUM

Our Living Ocean



THE 21st CENTURY WILL BE OCEANIC

NEPTUNE FORUM

June 8, 2026

World Ocean Day

Muséum national d'Histoire naturelle, Paris



REPORT

On World Ocean Day, Mission Neptune brought together on 8 June at the Muséum national d'Histoire naturelle in Paris more than 500 participants representing 43 nationalities, over 60 leading speakers — including one-third French personalities and two-thirds international experts — as well as more than 5,000 visitors over three days of programming.

One year to the day after the Third United Nations Ocean Conference (UNOC3), the gathering provided an opportunity to assess the progress achieved since Nice, review advances in ocean diplomacy, and chart the next steps for international action. At the intersection of science, exploration and cooperation, the Forum reaffirmed a strategic truth:

WE WILL ONLY BE ABLE TO PROTECT THE OCEAN SUSTAINABLY IF WE FIRST UNDERSTAND IT BETTER.

INTRODUCTION

Over three days of public programming under the banner Les Rêves de l'Océan, visitors took part in a series of events dedicated to ocean exploration: screenings of international scientific documentaries (including three world premieres), the photographic exhibition *The Botos – Spirits of the Amazon* by Prince Hussain Aga Khan in the Grand Gallery of Evolution, and the immersive experience *Ocean Dreams*, a film produced by Voice of the Ocean and Deep Sea Productions, presented inside the Neptune Explorers Dome at the Jardin des Plantes.

Bringing together more than 500 participants from all continents and more than 60 high-level speakers, the Neptune Mission Forum gathered scientists, explorers, ministers, diplomats, international organizations, philanthropic foundations, investors and representatives of civil society around a common conviction: better understanding the Ocean is the prerequisite for its protection and sustainable governance.

Designed as a nearly twelve-hour journey connecting exploration, science, innovation, diplomacy, and collective action, the Forum featured several live international connections from the historic Verniquet Amphitheatre at the National Museum of Natural History, linking Paris with French Polynesia, Antarctica, China, Singapore, Kenya, and several major international organizations, including the World Bank, illustrating the truly global dimension of Ocean challenges.

The National Museum of Natural History provided an exceptional setting for the Neptune Forum, where science, culture, and commitment to life converged. At the heart of this setting, the historic Verniquet Amphitheatre was enhanced by immersive scenography, sound and light installations, and a curated selection of previously unseen images from some of the world's most important contemporary oceanographic expeditions, developed in collaboration with WMH Project and made possible through the support of Mission Neptune's patrons.

This unique environment helped make the day a collective experience combining knowledge, emotion, and wonder in service of a deeper understanding and stronger protection of the Ocean.



~ BLUE DIPLOMACY ~ AND POLITICAL LEADERSHIP

France demonstrated its commitment through the participation of four government ministers:

- **Philippe Baptiste**, Minister for Higher Education, Research and Space
- **Monique Barbut**, Minister for Ecological Transition, Biodiversity and International Negotiations on Climate and Nature
- **Éléonore Caroit**, Minister Delegate for Francophonie, International Partnerships and French Nationals Abroad
- **Catherine Chabaud**, Minister Delegate for the Sea and Fisheries

These discussions took place in the continuity of UNOC 3 and highlighted the urgent need to accelerate implementation of the commitments made in Nice.

Minister Baptiste recalled that Mission Neptune was launched under the high patronage of the President of the French Republic, praised the global scale it has already reached, and reminded participants that “we are all children of Neptune.”

One of the Forum’s most significant moments was the establishment of a live satellite connection with the Presidency of French Polynesia in Papeete.

- **Le Président Moetai Brotherson**, speaking from the Council of Ministers chamber, emphasized that for Pacific peoples, the Ocean is far more than an economic resource: it is a space of life, memory, and identity. He announced strengthened protection measures for Polynesian waters within the world’s largest marine protected area, covering nearly 4.8 million km².
- Guest of honor and patron of Mission Neptune, Dr. Sylvia Earle welcomed this announcement, reminding participants that our generation has a unique window of opportunity to preserve the living system that makes life on Earth possible.
- The European Commission was represented by **Costas Kadis**, European Commissioner for Fisheries and Oceans. He introduced the new Ocean Eye initiative, integrated into the European Ocean Pact, as a framework designed to bring together Europe’s capacities for observation, exploration, and modeling.

This architecture notably relies on the Global Ocean Observing System (GOOS) for observation, Mission Neptune for scientific exploration, and Mercator Ocean International for the development of the European Digital Twin of the Ocean.

Discussions emphasized the complementarity between satellites, in situ observation networks, research vessels, autonomous technologies, and artificial intelligence. None of these tools alone can provide a complete understanding of the Ocean.

This convergence between space-based observation, in situ observation, exploration, and modeling was presented as one of the foundations of the future global Ocean knowledge system, serving both science and public decision-making.

Many speakers stressed that in the 21st century, understanding the Ocean now requires connecting space, sea, and data within a single global knowledge infrastructure.



~ THE VOICES OF INTERNATIONAL DIPLOMACY

In addition to Minister Éléonore Caroit and Ambassador Olivier Poivre d'Arvor, the Forum convened a number of leading figures at the forefront of major international negotiations.

- **Julio Cordano**, Ambassador for Environmental Affairs, Climate Change and Oceans at Chile's Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Chair of the United Nations Intergovernmental Negotiating Committee on the Global Plastics Treaty, and **Barbara Pompili**, France's Ambassador for the Environment, emphasized the urgency of reaching an ambitious and legally binding international agreement against plastic pollution.
- **Manuel Barange**, Assistant Director-General of the FAO and Director of the Fisheries and Aquaculture Division, reminded participants that approximately one in five fish consumed globally still comes from illegal, unreported, or unregulated fishing.
- **Arsenio Dominguez**, Secretary-General of the International Maritime Organization, stressed the need to accelerate the decarbonization of global maritime transport and strengthen the resilience of maritime routes in the face of climate change.
- **Leticia Reis de Carvalho**, Secretary-General of the International Seabed Authority, highlighted the international community's responsibility in managing deep-sea mineral resources as the common heritage of humankind, emphasizing the need for stronger scientific knowledge before any decisions regarding exploitation.

Voices from the Global South also played a central role in the discussions.

- **Lynda Tabuya**, Fiji's Minister for Fisheries and Forests, defended the essential role of Indigenous communities in Ocean governance.
- **Emelia Arthur**, Ghana's Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture, called for fairer representation of African countries in international institutions and stronger marine scientific capacities across the continent.

~ OCEAN GOVERNANCE AND PROTECTION IN FRANCE

- **Monique Barbut** and **Catherine Chabaud** announced the creation of three new highly protected marine zones: Audierne Bay in Brittany, a new protected zone in Guadeloupe, and an extension of protections in the French Southern and Antarctic Territories..

These measures increase the share of French waters under strong protection to nearly 14.68%, marking an important milestone in delivering on the commitments made during UNOC-3.

~ THE STATE OF THE OCEAN: ~ SCIENCE, OBSERVATION AND OCEAN ~ INTELLIGENCE

The Neptune Forum, held under the co-presidency of François Houllier, President and CEO of IFREMER, and Antje Boetius, President and CEO of MBARI, placed the health of the Ocean and the knowledge infrastructures required for its protection at the heart of its discussions, drawing on the contributions of Mission Neptune's Scientific Council, co-chaired by Margaret Leinen and Vladimir Ryabinin.

- **Dr Marina Lévy** and **Pierre Bahurel** presented the second edition of the Starfish Barometer, developed by a committee of 29 scientists from 14 countries.

The report highlights several alarming trends: more than 80% of the world's coral reefs have experienced bleaching events, global Ocean observation capacities are declining, while the Ocean continues to absorb around 25% of anthropogenic CO₂ emissions and nearly 90% of excess heat generated by human activity.

The Starfish Barometer is intended to become an annual scientific benchmark published on World Ocean Day.

- **Dr Robert Blasiak**, from the Stockholm Resilience Centre, warned against the risk of "flying blind" in climate, fisheries, and biodiversity policies without adequate observation infrastructures.

Sessions dedicated to Ocean Intelligence and the Ocean-Space nexus brought together leaders of major international scientific infrastructures, including

- **James Morrison**, Director of Healthy Planet at the European Commission,
- **Dr. Joanna Post**, Director of GOOS
- **Sophie Seeyave**, CEO, Partnership for Observation of the Global Oceans (POGO)

Discussions demonstrated that the next frontier of Ocean action lies in the ability to connect exploration, observation, digital modeling, and artificial intelligence to transform scientific data into faster and more effective public decision-making.

~ INNOVATION ~ AND NEW FRONTIERS ~ OF KNOWLEDGE

- **Andrew Forrest** and the scientific teams of the Minderoo Foundation presented the rapid advances in environmental DNA (eDNA), a technology capable of identifying species present in an ecosystem from a single water sample.

Thousands of kits have already been deployed worldwide, paving the way for unprecedented mapping of global marine biodiversity.

- **Michel André**, founder of the Sense of Silence Foundation, reminded participants that sound is the primary means of communication, orientation, and perception for many marine species. He called for noise pollution to be recognized as a major priority of Ocean governance.

~ MISSION NEPTUNE ~ IN ACTION

The Neptune Forum marked the first major public presentation of Mission Neptune since its launch in Nice in June 2025.

Participants discovered the first expeditions supported by the Mission (OceanX, Tara) as well as its international scientific roadmap structured around major knowledge challenges: marine habitats, seamount biodiversity, Ocean carbon sinks, polar oceans, hydrothermal vents, Ocean abundance, and new generations of digital models.

The Neptune Fellows program was officially presented, featuring four inaugural researchers from leading international institutions :

- **Olivia Soares Pereira** (Hydrothermal Vents, MBARI)
- **Neha Acharya-Patel** (Ocean Abundance, Scripps Institution of Oceanography)
- **Shawnee Traylor** (Carbon sinks, MBARI)
- **Guillaume Liniger** (Polar Oceans, MBARI)

These young scientists embody Mission Neptune's commitment to supporting a new generation of researchers working at the intersection of science, technology, and international cooperation.

The Forum also announced the development of the first Neptune Chairs (Tahiti, Sharjah, Rabat, and Paris), as well as the Neptune Explorers Galleries, designed to bring the public closer to Ocean exploration through immersive, cultural, and educational experiences.

Several speakers highlighted the role Mission Neptune could play in implementing the High Seas Treaty (BBNJ), particularly through shared exploration capacities, scientific data sharing, and the development of knowledge needed to establish future marine protected areas on the high seas.



≈ CULTURE, NARRATIVES ≈ AND MOBILIZATION

Beyond scientific and diplomatic challenges, the Forum emphasized the essential role of culture and storytelling in mobilizing societies.

- **Jean-Louis Étienne** observed that the Ocean still does not inspire enough dreams, even though humanity's future depends on it.
- **Cyril Gomez**, from the Oceanographic Institute of Monaco, reminded participants that science alone will not save the Ocean, and that knowledge must be carried forward through emotion, culture, and civic engagement.
- **Jeremy Rifkin** called for a profound transformation in our relationship with life and advocated for a "Blue Deal" to complement today's major climate policies. "We live on Planet Aqua," he reminded the audience.
- Sylvia Earle's presence served as one of the day's central threads. In her opening remarks, she reminded participants that the Ocean is not simply a resource, but the planet's life-support system. Her message, met with a long standing ovation, captured the spirit of the Forum: "Taking care of the Ocean is a team sport."
- **Le Prince Hussain Aga Khan** also emphasized the unique power of imagery to create an emotional connection with life and mobilize new audiences for Ocean protection.



CONCLUSION

The inaugural Neptune Forum demonstrated both the vitality and urgency that characterize today's international Ocean community.

Six major messages emerged from the day:

- 1 The gap between knowledge and action must be bridged;
- 2 Ocean observation infrastructures are under threat at the very moment they are most needed;
- 3 Equity and inclusion are indispensable conditions for effectiveness;
- 4 Culture and emotion are essential drivers of transformation;
- 5 Ocean exploration must become an international strategic priority comparable to major space programs;
- 6 France intends to continue its leadership on Ocean issues and invites other States to strengthen their commitments.



From left to right : Sanna Johansen, Carl Douglas, Jean-Marc Daniel, Ali Hilal-Alnaqbi, Vladimir Ryabinin, Olivier Poivre d'Arvor, Antje Boetius, Prince Hussain Aga Khan, Philippe Baptiste, Sylvia Earle, François Houllier, H.E. Sheikh Fahim Bin Sultan Bin Khalid Al Qasimi, Margaret Leinen, Emelia Arthur, Holly Buschman, Ashok Adicéam, Teodora Stojilkovic



ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The Mission Neptune team extends its sincere gratitude to all speakers, moderators, partners, and participants who contributed to the success of this inaugural edition.

Special thanks to IFREMER and all its teams for their support, as well as to the National Museum of Natural History for its exceptional hospitality;

to the Ministry for Europe and Foreign Affairs, the Ministry for Higher Education, Research and Space, the Ministry for Ecological Transition, and the Ministry Delegate for the Sea and Fisheries;

to the President of French Polynesia and all governmental and diplomatic representatives;

to Dr. Sylvia Earle, Prince Hussain Aga Khan, Andrew Forrest, Carl Douglas, Sanna Johansen, and Fred Tsao for their trust and constant inspiration;

to Franck Chaud, WMH Project, and all their teams for executive production;

to the young postdoctoral Neptune Fellows, who embody the next generation of Ocean scientists;

as well as to the founding members of Mission Neptune: Ifremer, MBARI, Minderoo Foundation, Voice of the Ocean, OceanX, Focused on Nature, the Oceanographic Institute of Monaco, TPC Group, and the University of Khorfakkan, together with all partners who contributed to the success of this inaugural edition of the Mission Neptune Forum.

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Mission Neptune is a global initiative supporting the operational deployment of oceanEye, within the European Ocean Pact, in partnership with GOOS and Mercator Ocean International.



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